

EXPLORE PHP ON YOUR ANDROID DEVICE



For Web developers who want to try hands-on Android development, not having a Java background is an issue. Thankfully, SL4A comes to their rescue.

The Scripting Layer for Android, usually called SL4A, brings scripting layers to the Android platform, along with some interactive interpreters that allow developers to edit and execute scripts on the device itself. This project for developers is an initiative by Damon Kohler and has been released under the Apache License 2.0. These scripts enable access to many APIs available to Android applications, and these have been provided with greatly simplified interfaces to add to the developer's comfort. Currently, SL4A officially supports Python, Perl, JRuby, Lua, BeanShell, JavaScript, Tcl and shell scripts.

PHP for Android

The PHP for Android (PFA) project by Irontec aims at feasible PHP development on Android. Initiated by Ivan Mosquera Paulo in 2010, it helps you write and edit the PHP scripts on your Android device itself, and even create entire Android applications in PHP. Basically, the PFA is itself an Android application (.apk file) that provides installation for a PHP-CLI binary linked to *bionic* (Android's *libc*) and for two built-in extensions, *sockets* and *JSON*, required to talk to the Android Scripting Environment (ASE). Hence, there is no need of a

Web server. PHP-CLI and GUI access is enough, and this is provided by ASE's *Remote Procedure Call (RPC)* server.

The PHP coding standard followed here is Zend:

```
phpcs --standard=Zend script.php
```

Installation

Developers need an Android device running v1.5 or later; you can also use the emulator. For a real Android device, enable 'Unknown Sources' under application settings.

1. Installing SL4A: Download and install the latest version from <http://code.google.com/p/android-scripting/downloads/list>. SL4A comes only with a shell interpreter by default. You may install additional features as per your needs.
2. Installing PHP for Android (PFA): Download and install the latest version of PFA from <http://phpforandroid.net/releases>. This is an installer that will install the following files on your device:
 - i. *php_rX.zip*, which is a PHP binary.
 - ii. *php_extras_rX.zip*, which includes *Android.php* and *php.ini* files.
 - iii. *php_scripts_rX.zip* includes demo scripts.